

Does the new language match your way of thinking?

A friend of mine has a PhD in computer science and has a mathematical bent of mind. He came to know about a language called APL (A Programming Language), which supports mathematical notation. He liked the idea of 'notation as a tool of thought' and started learning it. I wasn't convinced about his idea of learning an esoteric language like APL till he demonstrated his power to solve some real problems with one-liners (that would normally take tens of lines solving in mainstream languages like Java)! Since the APL way of thinking matched my friend's mindset, he loved the language and could make the best use of it, becoming hyper-productive in solving his problems.

Does the new language help you think differently?

Learning a new language should help you think differently. Note that 'thinking differently' does not conflict with my previous point on the language matching your way of thinking - unless you try a different way of thinking and problem-solving, how do you know if it matches your way of thinking, right! If you are a programmer with exposure to statically typed languages such as C and Java, try a dynamically typed language such as Smalltalk and Objective-C. If you know only object-oriented languages such as Ruby or C#, try logical or functional languages such as Prolog or Clojure. If you have used only graphical languages like Visual Basic, try learning a scripting language to automate your tasks, such as Python and Perl. When you try different approaches to solving the same problem, you'll find that there are often easier and better ways to

solving the same problem (and hence this will help you become more productive).

Does the new language excite you?

When I was talking to a friend who was learning Clojure, I couldn't resist noticing his excitement about discovering the 'Lisp' way of thinking and solving problems. When I tried Clojure, I only got frustrated (not excited). Hence, before you decide to take the leap and spend months or years learning a new language, do check if learning that new language excites you.

Never before in the history of computing have we had so many choices before us. For example, as I write this article, I see a mail popping into my inbox about RedHat announcing the release of its new language named Ceylon. We are also at a point of transition - the erstwhile mainstream languages like Java, C, C++, etc, were designed for the old era. In this decade in which computers are shrinking to the size of a button, the Internet is becoming ubiquitous, computing is becoming a paid and pervasive service, and data is growing to the order of exabytes, the dominant languages will be completely different. More than anything else, learning a new language is fun! So what are you waiting for - go ahead, carefully choose, and then enjoy learning a new programming language! 

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OSFY Magazine Attractions During 2013-14

MONTH	THEME	FEATURED LIST
March 2013	Virtualisation	Virtualisation Solution Providers
April 2013	Open source Databases	Certification & Training Solution Providers
May 2013	Network Monitoring	Mobile Apps
June 2013	Open Source application development	Cloud
July 2013	Open Source on Windows	Web Hosting Providers
August 2013	Open Source Firewall and Network security	E-mail Service Providers
September 2013	Android Special	Gadgets
October 2013	Kernel Special	IT Consultancy
November 2013	Cloud Special	IT Hardware
December 2013	Linux & Open Source Powered Data Storage	Network Storage
January 2014	Open Source for Web development and deployment	Security
February 2014	Top 10 of Everything on Open Source	IT Infrastructure